



HUM 101 Final Take Home Project: Analytical Essay

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Section: 03

Introduction:

Interconnections have always played an important part in the development of human history. This allows societies to share ideas, goods and beliefs. These interconnections and exchanges between different societies create a link among them that shapes civilizations in many ways. According to Abu-Lughod, "The interconnectedness of societies through trade and communication has been a driving force in the evolution of human cultures" (Abu-Lughod, 1989, n.p.). In the ancient world, the interconnection between different societies occurred in many ways. Land routes and maritime routes played a huge role in this interconnection among societies. The Silk Roads and maritime trade networks are two examples of how the interactions of different societies influenced the ancient world. These routes did not act just as pathways for trade and commerce. They also acted as gateways for the exchange of technology, cultures, norms and most importantly religions. Universal religions like Buddhism and Islam spread rapidly throughout the ancient world because of these land and maritime routes. These religions not only spread through various geographical locations but also restructured the societies that they touched. The spread of Buddhism through the Silk Roads is one of the earliest examples of religious globalisation. This spreading of this religion was not an accident. It was facilitated by the acts of the merchants and the monks who were transporting teachings and texts along with relics. Local rulers along the Silk Roads often patronised this religion for their own benefit. Buddhist monasteries across the Silk Road often acted as economic hubs, hostels and centres for exchanging ideas. Because travellers and traders used to stop there often for rest. But sometimes this ostensibly unifying force also revealed cultural and political difficulties. Many regions along the Silk Road modified their newly adopted Buddhist rituals in some unique way to align the religion with their local settings. These adjustments and unique adaptations reflect the conflict of universal religions as they offer a shared framework while highlighting regional disparities. In the same way, the rise of Islam across Indian Ocean trade networks and the Mongol kingdoms also shows the two faces of universal religions. The widespread spread of Islam encompassed both conversion and integration. Arab traders and settlers introduced their beliefs while trading goods. In this way, Islam integrated into the local

civilisations through trading, intermarriage and cultural interchange. It was the Mongols who are often perceived in many accounts as destroyers of civilisations but later on facilitated the spread of Islam. Their empire bridged the exchanges between distant lands which allowed an unprecedented level of knowledge and belief to flow through. Although Islam was spreading rapidly because of its flexibility, some internal divisions were also emerging. Differences in beliefs and practices like Sufi mystics and Salafism often created new divisions. Different sects also added to these divisions within the Islamic world throughout the region. These two universal religions were two great factors in world history. The real question here is whether universal religions unified men or they caused divisions with the introduction of new ways and ideas. Both religions created common beliefs and practices. The interaction of distant regions became possible with the help of religion. But at the same time, they also challenged old traditions as well as created different sects and divisions. This essay will explore how merchants, monks, and monasteries played a pivotal role in the spreading of Buddhism along the Silk Roads through trade and cultural exchange as well as the influence of local rulers who patronized Buddhist practices for political and cultural gains. Moreover, the study will explore how Islam spread through the Indian Ocean trade networks and the Mongol Empire while highlighting how Arab traders facilitated its integration through commerce, intermarriage, and cultural exchange and how the Mongols facilitated religious exchanges across vast territories. Finally, this essay will critically assess whether universal religions like Buddhism and Islam unified societies by establishing shared beliefs and cultural ties or introduced divisions by challenging traditional beliefs and fostering internal sectarian conflicts.

Body para 1:

The first body paragraph will explore how Buddhism spread along the Silk Roads with the help of merchants, monks, and monasteries, as well as the critical support of local rulers who endorsed and promoted Buddhist practices. The spread of Buddhism by merchants,

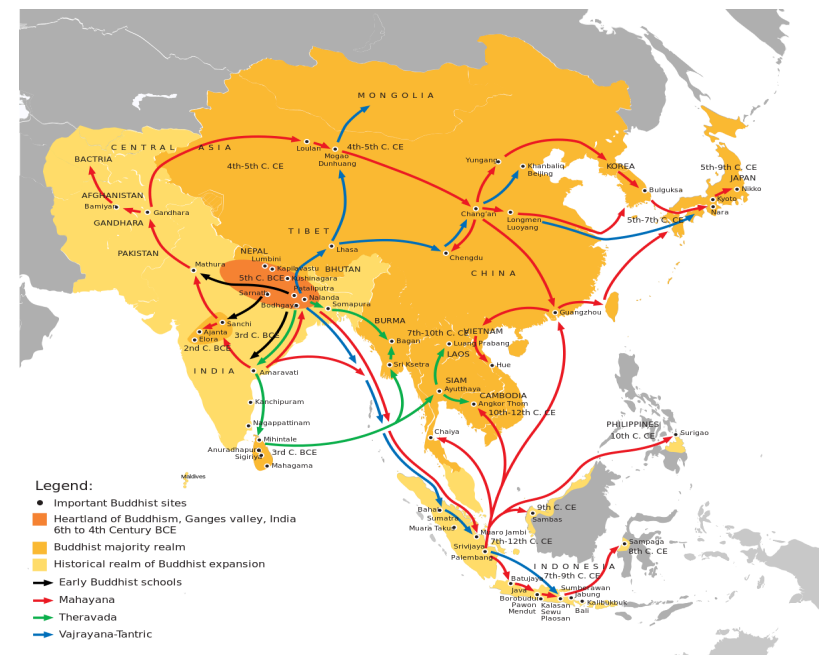
monks, and monasteries along the Silk Roads was a dynamic process. Especially, merchants played a huge role by serving as carriers of both material goods and cultural ideas. These merchants carried sacred texts, religious art and relics from India and spread them throughout Asia. Trade networks of Buddhist merchants were spread from India to Central Asia and China which helped to establish Buddhism in numerous areas that had never experienced the religion before. These merchants exchanged not only goods but also philosophical ideas and religious practices with the communities they met.

The monks also boosted the spread of Buddhism significantly while travelling frequently along the trade routes and actively engaging with local populations. They carried sacred texts with them while travelling through the trade routes. These monks translated and adapted these sacred texts into local languages and made Buddhist teachings accessible to new audiences. Buddhism spread through the exchange of texts, monks, and objects between South Asia and China, which impacted Central and Southeast Asia (Kedar et al., 2015). Prominent monks like Xuanzang journeyed from China to India in search of authentic Buddhist texts. Upon his return, he translated these texts into Chinese. These translated texts have made Chinese Buddhism very profound and helped the religion interlink into Chinese culture. Usually, monks would travel in company with merchant caravans and serve as spiritual guides. They used to provide moral and ethical teachings to the traders and the people of the local population. In this way, merchants and monks partnered to ensure that Buddhism was both spread down the trade routes and sustained.

The monasteries also became vital centres of Buddhist teaching and cultural exchange across the Silk Roads. Most monasteries had been constructed near major trading centres. This helped to provide rest and hospitality for travellers like merchants and monks. Monasteries were not only temples but also a place of learning and exchanging ideologies. Nalanda Mahavihara became the primary Buddhist learning centre by the seventh century which began to draw students from all over Asia (Kedar et al., 2015). Local people were also trained in monastery Buddhist practices in monasteries. It helped to create a network of converts and practitioners who themselves could spread the religion even more across the relevant regions. The Silk Road spread across central Asia and connected a vast area of the ancient world especially parts of Asia, the Middle East and Europe. This road allowed goods like spices, silk and

various precious metals throughout the region. These goods or products were also travelled through the maritime routes as well. Maritime trade routes linking the Bay of Bengal to the South China Sea also helped to spread Buddhism. Ships carrying goods from India to other areas would stop at different Southeast Asian ports where Buddhist monks built up monasteries and engaged in cultural exchange.

Another crucial aspect in the expansion of Buddhism along the Silk Roads was the influence of local rulers. Many rulers viewed Buddhism as one way of unifying their territories and establishing the legitimacy of their authority. The most notable in this respect was the Kushan Empire, where King Kanishka played a significant role in the diffusion of Mahayana Buddhism (Kedar et al., 2015). Mahayana Buddhism was especially fit for gaining adherents in almost all diversities of regions due to its ideal of the Bodhisattva and inclusiveness. Kanishka's patronage of the Fourth Buddhist Council and his support for Mahayana Buddhism helped in the spread of this religion as far as Central Asia and even beyond.



One of the formidable strengths of Buddhism was its ability to create a shared religious culture across huge territories. Buddhism remained effective upon passing into other cultures and ethnic groups because it advocated universal values and convictions like compassion, meditation and ethical living. As the Silk Road was a vast network of road system, the people who lived along with it were from different cultures and societies. But the universality of Buddhism helped bridge the divides between various societies along

the Silk Roads. This thing then fostered a sense of shared identity and purpose. The religion provided a common moral and spiritual level on which the systematically different groups could interact and work together better.

However, Buddhism also spread along the Silk Roads with challenges and divergences. Buddhism often incorporated elements from existing traditions and created regional variations in Buddhist practice and belief. That's how Mahayana Buddhism flourished in China while the dominant form of Buddhism became Theravada Buddhism in Southeast Asia. Mahayana Buddhism's attraction in China resided in its universalist approach and its teaching of compassion, which integrated with Confucian norms, whereas Theravada Buddhism in Southeast Asia maintained its focus on individual enlightenment (Zürcher, 2007). All such differences enriched the overall tradition but simultaneously promoted internal divisions within the Buddhist community. Besides, the dominance of Buddhism in certain areas were also contested with the emerging other strong religious traditions.

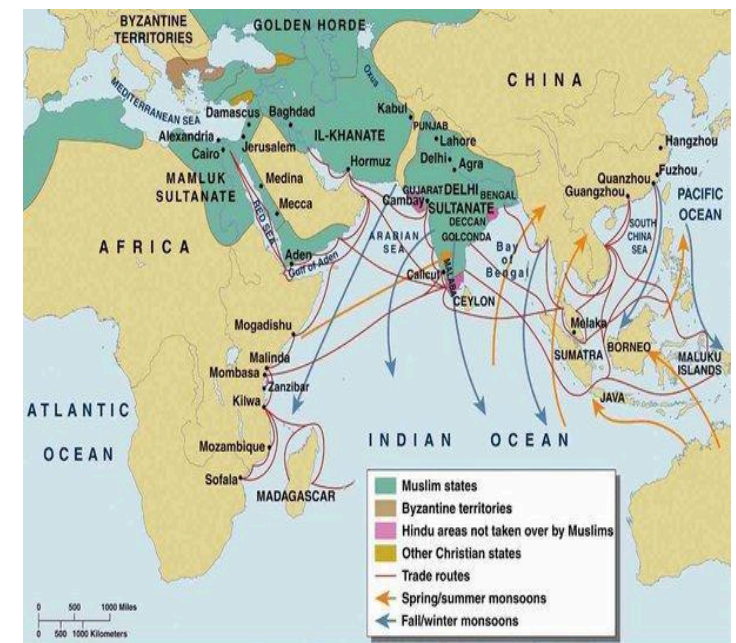
But, because it could be adapted to local contexts, Buddhism remained relevant and influential along the Silk Routes. The spread of Buddhism along the Silk Roads was an exceedingly complex and multi-dimensional process. It became the first pan-Asiatic religion to connect regions through trade, cultural exchange, and religious practices. Patronage from local rulers allowed the religion to be assimilated into diverse cultures and societies more easily. Although the spread of Buddhism resulted in a variety of internal traditions, it maintained a religiously unified culture that ultimately transformed into new political identities and established diplomatic relations across Asia.

Body paragraph 2:

The paragraph will focus on the spread of Islam through Indian Ocean maritime networks led by Arab traders while emphasizing their contributions to commerce, intermarriage, and cultural exchange and also will examine the Mongol Empire's efforts to foster Islamic religious integration across its vast domains.

The Arab traders were the most important figures associated with the expansion of Islam along the Indian Ocean trade routes. These Arab traders were actively navigating the maritime routes connecting the Arabian Peninsula with East Africa, South Asia, and Southeast Asia from the early age of Islam. They were not only exchanging practical commodities like spices, textiles, and precious metals but also exchanging their Islamic beliefs while trading. They were not just marchents and traders, we were also like messenger of a new belief. Being merchants earned them a special status in the key port cities where many of them often married into the local communities. These intermarriages developed unique cultural identities and blended Islamic traditions with those of the local populations. Swahili city states in the coastal regions of East Africa can be shown as examples. These city-states were established by Arab traders where Islam became a dominant cultural and religious influence. This cross-cultural interaction formed a cosmopolitan culture deeply enshrined in Islamic values yet adaptive to local traditions.

Commerce was also a powerful tool that helped spread Islam. Muslim traders used to follow Islamic principles and beliefs in their business, which made them trustworthy to other non-Muslim traders and locals. Those honest merchants were often stood out and noticed by others and many non-Muslims embraced Islam due to the excellent values carried by Muslims. Trade agreements and similar ways of worship created bonding between the various merchants. This bonding too contributed to the growth of Islam beyond religion. Also, the rulers of some trading areas, like the Malabar Coast of the southwest coast of India welcomed the Muslim merchants (Alpers & Edward A, 2014). It was because these merchants helped to



MAP 1-3 THE ISLAMIC WORLD AND TRADE, 1335

boost their economy and brought new ideas. Over time, the interactions among them worked towards making Islam an important part of the cultural and religious life of these regions.

On the other hand, the Mongol Empire helped the religion to grow on land. In the 13th and 14th centuries, the Mongols presided over a huge empire, extending from China into Europe. This huge empire was a melting pot of cultures, religions, and people. Although the Mongols were originally not Muslims, some rulers, like the rulers of the Golden Horde and the Ilkhanate converted to Islam. These conversions propagated the influence of Islam in Central Asia and the Middle East. The rulers established and supported mosques and schools for teaching purposes which also helped to spread Islamic ideas throughout the empire. Rashid al-Din portrayed how the Mongols supported Islam in his work. He was the great historian of the Mongol Empire who had written a book entitled *Jami' al-Tawarikh* or *Compendium of Chronicles*. He had written this book explaining how the Mongols united most of the cultures and religions including Islam. Their support for Islam allowed scholars, traders and religious leaders to move freely across the empire. And this support and freedom were the ones that made possible the spread of Islam to new areas and helped in exchanging ideas. The Mongols facilitated Islam from Persia to China. The Indian Ocean trade routes also helped in the spreading of Islamic culture in new ways. Along with the products, the traders carried Islamic teachings and practices to faraway places. Sufi mystics often travelled with such traders. Suffis focused their efforts on converting people to Islam through personal relationships and peaceful teaching. They established religious communities in new regions and adapted Islamic customs to match local norms.

The reasons why Islam became a universal religion in the Indian Ocean region were because of its acceptance of diversified cultures and the use of local cultural tools. This adaptation and incorporation of local architecture and hybrid identities in Islam allowed this religion to survive and prosper within multicultural societies. With the help of scholars and Sufis, Islamic teachings were translated

into local languages. This made it possible for a wider audience to access and understand the religion's principles. Thus more and more people came to know about Islam which helped in the spreading of this religion across Indian Ocean trade routes.

Islamic merchants and Arab settlers had a vital role in exploiting contact expansion to spread the religion throughout the Indian Ocean territory. Probably the most important consequence was the way Islam reached East Africa. The religion merged with local beliefs to form a rich and distinctive Swahili culture. Swahili culture developed around the East African coast because of the interaction between the Arab Muslim traders and the communities that lived there. The resulting mix fused Islamic religion with local beliefs and developed a special and dynamic urban culture (Beaujard, 2019). Evidence of this cultural mix can be seen everywhere across the Swahili Coast. However, Islam primarily reached Southeast Asia via Arabian and Indian merchants who were engaged in trade. The large trading cities like Malacca made the local ruling houses, local culture, and local commerce identical to Islam. The religion gained that special attractiveness of association with prosperous trading communities which the rulers and local elites were eager to emulate. Islam's tolerant nature also contributed to its endurance and durability throughout the Indian Ocean region. By adopting local customs, it formed deep roots in cultures that were highly diverse and decentralised. The religion's ability to connect trade networks, cultural traditions, and governance systems across the Indian Ocean built a foundation for persistent social and economic exchanges. It allowed connectivity and interaction among Muslim communities across a wide Indian Ocean world in the exchange of ideas, knowledge, and goods. This connectedness fostered commerce and technology as well as the growth of an Islamic identity spanning geographical boundaries. It left a lasting legacy of cultural and religious unity.

Body para 3:

This paragraph will examine the dual role of universal religions by exploring whether they primarily unified societies or introduced divisions through the creation of sectarian differences. Universal religions like Buddhism and Islam attempted to create some kind of universal culture across regions which mostly resulting in both unity and division. A very distinctive example of such division could be the persecution of Buddhists during the Tang Dynasty in China when Emperor Wuzong initiated a campaign against Buddhist monasteries that had been destroyed (BROSE, B. (2014). Persecution occurred not only because of political and economic causes but also due to the foreign character of Buddhism. This foreign character of Buddhism conflicted with traditional Confucian and Taoist values. It proves that the acceptance of a universal religion could serve as a reason for resistance and a cause of division in societies.

In the same way, Vajrayana Buddhism was removed from Bengal which underlines the ideological differences within Buddhism as a whole. The different school of thought and practice that Vajrayana Buddhism undertook was overtaken by more dominant Buddhist traditions. Different cultural divergence and local adaptation of the religion resulted in various differences amongst the followers of Buddhism. This results internal conflicts instead of creating unity. These internal conflicts have weakened the religious community in respective regions.

Similarly, the internal divisions within Islam also reflected the dual nature of its role both as a unifier and a divider. In the Indian subcontinent, there are Shafi and Hanafi Muslims. These two sects of Muslims reflect how ideological interpretations can create sectarian divides. There can be many reasons these divisions can be influenced by, such as regional cultural practices, political alignment, and for military reasons. While Islam aimed to create a unified ummah of believers, these sectarian conflicts show how universal religions could fragment societies. However, these issues did not stop universal religions from trying to work through a common culture by adapting to the local worldview. Mahayana Buddhism demonstrates how a universal religion evolved to accommodate diverse cultural contexts. Mahayana teachings emphasise a more doctrinal approach to enlightenment and compassion for all living beings, which allowed Buddhism to integrate into other cultures without abandoning its essential principles. This is the adaptability that helped to create a sense of unity among diverse followers across the Silk Roads.

Also, Sufism did much to unify the communities. Sufi practices often used local customs to make Islam easily accessible to its people. In South Asia, Sufi saints and scholars integrated Islamic teachings with regional customs which helped to establish a sense of kinship among local groups. This highlights how universal religions can act as bridges between different cultures by adapting and integrating with the local customs. Another example is the facilitation of connections between the most distant regions by Islam in the Indian Ocean trade circuits. Arab traders and settlers brought along Islamic ways of life while respecting local traditions at the same time. This integration created a common cultural framework that enables communities across the Indian Ocean to interact and cooperate.

However, common cultures produced new world divisions at the same time. Almost everywhere, universal religions stirred new challenges to old systems of power and ways of living. Tensions developed between converts to universal religions and those devoted to older faiths and local beliefs. For instance, the accommodation of Buddhism within Confucian and Taoist societies was not without its conflicts in China. Many local rulers and elites were hostile towards the spread of Buddhism because it undermined their cultural and political authority. These tensions expose the difficulties of how universal religions interacted with traditional cultures.

Although there are some differences, universal religions like Buddhism and Islam did create a world of similarities and differences at the same time. Both Islam and Buddhism provided shared practices and philosophical ideas that united these communities around and across the Indian Ocean and along the Silk Routes (Chaudhuri, 1985). They offered common ideas and practices by which distant communities could relate and interact. However, while expanding, they introduced new ideals and ideologies that challenged existing traditions and cultural practices. This dual role of universal religions underlines the crucial role they played in the cultural and social reconfigurations of Afro-Eurasia.

So we can say that the function of Buddhism and Islam was not single in nature but rather dual. Because while they unified societies by creating common cultural ties, they also introduced divisions with sectarian conflicts and divisions along ideological grounds. Examples like the Mahayana Buddhism, Sufism and Indian Ocean trade circuits show how religions grew to accommodate diverse

worldviews. But at the same time, there are also counterbalances to the examples of how unity is hard. For instance, Tang Dynasty persecution of Buddhists and sectarian conflicts within Islam. So it can be said that universal religions like Islam and Buddhism created common cultural frameworks across Eurasia while simultaneously triggering new world divides through ideological and sectarian conflicts.

Conclusion:

In conclusion, the expansion of universal religions like Buddhism and Islam affected cultures and politics throughout Eurasia and the Indian Ocean. They built such strong ties that stretched beyond regional bounds. Buddhism expanded along the Silk Roads through the active role of merchant groups, monks as well as monastic complexes. These monks and monasteries helped disseminate Buddhist ideas and also served as a place of rest for travellers. Some local rulers also supported and helped the spreading of Buddhism for political and economic reasons. The Kushan Empire made Buddhism a strong cultural force. Similarly, Islam also spread widely through the Indian Ocean trade and the Mongol Empire. The Arab merchants shared their Islamic teachings and cultures while trading goods throughout the Indian Ocean trade route. Also, because of intermarriage between Arab Muslims and local women in several regions of the trade route, Islamic traditions got mixed with the local culture. This happened in East Africa, Southeast Asia, and other places. The Mongols also favoured religious tolerance and helped different cultures to exchange their ideas and goods. Buddhism and Islam brought people together and created shared beliefs and cultural ties. However, they caused some divisions too. In Islam, differences emerged between Sunni and Shia Muslims while in Buddhism, the Mahayana and Theravada traditions developed. The reasons for these differences reflect the different regions with different cultures in which these religions spread. However, despite all these challenges, both faiths helped to create a bridge between people. They turned trade routes into pathways of knowledge, art, and

spreading religion. It is from such connections that societies became wealthier and found a possible basis for today's globalization. The histories of Buddhism and Islam are histories of religions adjusting themselves to the local tradition. The spreading of Buddhism and Islam is a story of unity amidst diversity. They show that shared ideas and beliefs can connect people across great distances. These connections have left a strong mark on human history.

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